

STAGE THIRTEEN • TEAMWORK & COLLABORATION

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Thirteen • Teamwork & Collaboration

PURPOSE

Stage Thirteen is, almost by definition, a stage about doing things together — which makes it one of the richest in the program for genuine group adaptation. Nearly every FIRST here already assumes a real team; these adaptations add deliberate structure to make the team practice itself more effective, not just faster.

This document adapts eight FIRSTS across all three sections of Stage Thirteen. Unlike some other stages, these aren't optional additions on top of solo work — for a team-based stage, the structured group version often is the primary way to genuinely complete the exercise.

Each entry includes a suggested format, the extra time it adds beyond a purely discussion-based version, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a team, and a short note on why the structure specifically matters for that FIRST.

The Eight Adapted Exercises

FIRST Q2

Team Goal Alignment — Simultaneous Reveal

TIME: +10 min beyond framing

1. Each team member privately writes their own one-sentence understanding of the team's actual goal, without discussion.
2. All sentences are revealed simultaneously — written on cards, or shared on screen at once.
3. Team discusses any genuine differences found, and drafts one agreed sentence together.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Simultaneous reveal, not sequential sharing, is what makes this work — sequential sharing lets later speakers anchor to the first answer rather than giving their own genuine, independent read.

FIRST Q6

Collaborative Brainstorming Session — Silent-Start Brainstorm

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Give the team a real prompt, and have everyone write ideas silently and individually for 3 minutes first — no talking.
2. Go around and have each person share their ideas aloud, still without discussion or judgment, while someone captures them all visibly.
3. Only once every idea is on the table does the team discuss and group them.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A silent-start phase specifically protects quieter or slower-processing team members from having their ideas crowded out by faster, louder brainstorming — a genuine, common failure mode of unstructured group brainstorming.

FIRST Q7

Shared Decision-Making Exercise — Buy-In Temperature Check

TIME: +10 min beyond discussion

1. After discussing a real decision, each team member privately holds up a number of fingers (1–5) indicating genuine buy-in, revealed simultaneously.
2. Anyone below a 4 explains their specific concern before the team finalizes the decision.
3. Revisit the decision, incorporating what's genuinely addressable from the concerns raised.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly operationalizes the FIRST's core lesson — silence isn't the same as agreement — by making buy-in an explicit, visible, and simultaneous signal rather than an assumption.

FIRST Q11

Collaborative Problem-Solving Exercise — Structured Round-Robin

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Present a real, current team problem. Going around the group, each person contributes one observation or idea in turn — no one may speak twice until everyone has spoken once.
2. After the full round, the team discusses freely and converges on an approach.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This structural constraint is a simple, effective way to prevent the most vocal team member from dominating, directly addressing this FIRST's named Common Pitfall.

FIRST Q19

Peer Review Within a Team — Two-Question Review Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond individual review time

1. Each person brings a real piece of current work (or a draft from earlier in this stage).
2. In groups of 3, each person's work gets reviewed by the other two using exactly two questions: what's one thing that's genuinely working, and one specific thing you'd change?
3. Rotate until everyone's work has been reviewed.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Limiting feedback to two specific questions keeps peer review fast, concrete, and genuinely actionable, rather than open-ended feedback that tends to drift into vague or overly diplomatic territory.

FIRST Q23

Team Consensus Exercise — Concerns-First Consensus Build

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Present a real or realistic team decision with at least two reasonable options.
2. Before anyone states a preference, go around and have each person name one genuine concern about each option — concerns only, no preferences yet.
3. Only after every concern is on the table does the team discuss and work toward a decision that genuinely addresses the concerns raised.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Surfacing concerns before preferences prevents the group from anchoring early to whichever option the most persuasive person favors, which is what usually turns a real consensus attempt into a disguised majority vote.

FIRST Q25

Team Recognition Practice — Real-Time Shoutout Round

TIME: +10 min beyond framing

1. If real teams have worked together during this stage, each person names one specific, genuine contribution a teammate made during today's session — not a general compliment, something concrete they actually did or said.
2. Go around until everyone has both given and received one specific recognition.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Doing this live, about something that just happened in the room, makes the practice immediately concrete rather than abstract — and directly models the “in the moment, not just at the end” timing this FIRST is about.

FIRST Q27

Team Retrospective — Start / Stop / Continue

TIME: +15 min beyond individual reflection

1. Each team member individually writes one thing to start doing, one to stop doing, and one to continue doing, based on this stage's real team project.
2. Go around and share all three categories, collecting them visibly (whiteboard or shared doc).
3. As a team, agree on one specific commitment in each category to carry forward.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The Start/Stop/Continue structure is specifically designed to make room for genuine critique (Stop) alongside things that are working (Continue), directly countering this FIRST's named pitfall of only covering what went well.